



Mainland Company Formation In UAE

Establish a Legally Compliant, Fully Operational Presence in One of the World's Most Business-Friendly Economies

Mainland company formation in the United Arab Emirates (UAE) offers investors, entrepreneurs, and corporate entities the most versatile path to operating within the region's domestic economy.

Licensed by the respective Department of Economic Development (DED) in each emirate, Mainland companies are authorized to conduct business across the entire UAE, without geographic restrictions or limitations on client type – including both private sector and government contracts.



Why Mainland UAE Is the Strategic Choice for Ambitious Operators

Mainland UAE companies offer a unique combination of market access, operational freedom, and legal credibility. As regulatory reforms continue to align the UAE with global transparency standards, Mainland entities remain the preferred option for those seeking to engage in the local economy with full legal rights and strategic flexibility.

What You Gain with a UAE Mainland License

100% Foreign Ownership

With sweeping reforms introduced in recent years, most commercial and professional business activities now qualify for full foreign ownership. Investors no longer require a UAE national partner for the majority of licenses — offering control, freedom, and peace of mind from day one.

Unrestricted Access to the UAE Market

Mainland companies are licensed to operate across all seven emirates, without geographical or client-type restrictions. Whether you're targeting consumers, businesses, or government contracts — you're free to trade across industries and borders within the UAE.

Eligibility for Government Contracts and Tenders

Mainland companies are the only type of entities eligible to bid on government tenders. In 2023 alone, the UAE allocated over AED 17.5 billion to infrastructure, education, and public projects — including AED 4+ billion on public works. As a licensed Mainland firm, you gain access to these lucrative opportunities.

Freedom to Open Branches Across the UAE

Unlike Free Zone companies, which are geographically limited, Mainland businesses can open and operate multiple branch offices anywhere in the country – from major metros to remote emirates.

Flexible Business Locations – Not Tied to One Zone

Mainland businesses can establish operations wherever strategic – near seaports, airports, industrial zones, or central business districts. You're not restricted by zone-based rules, clustering requirements, or location mandates.

Wide Activity Range and Easy Expansion

With over 2,000+ approved activities under the DED, Mainland companies enjoy the widest operational scope. Expanding into new verticals? You don't need to form a new company – simply update your license with the new activity. DSA handles the full process without interrupting your existing operations.

Visa Sponsorship and Residency Flexibility

Mainland companies can apply for investor, partner, and employee visas under scalable quotas – including long-term Golden Visas for qualified shareholders and senior professionals. Visa allocations are tied to your office size, business model, and operational needs – not capped by zone rules.

Full Repatriation of Capital and Profits

There are no restrictions on moving your earnings abroad. Mainland companies can repatriate 100% of their profits and capital without withholding taxes or remittance barriers.

Local Credibility and Professional Standing

Mainland businesses hold higher credibility among UAE-based clients, banks, and government bodies — especially in regulated sectors like legal, medical, engineering, and consulting. If your clientele is local or regulatory-heavy, a Mainland license signals trust.

Visa Sponsorship and Residency Flexibility

Unlike Free Zone entities, which cannot contract directly with UAE ministries or authorities, Mainland companies are eligible to work with government and semi-government bodies across all sectors.

Business Activities in SPC Free Zone

Publishing & Media

SPC is the world's first free zone for publishers and remains a hub for content creation. Activities include book publishing, printing, digital platforms, film, media production, and advertising agencies. Its strong ecosystem makes it ideal for creative ventures.

[Click here](#)

Consultancy & Professional Services

Licenses cover management, HR, IT, marketing, and training consultancy. These businesses operate flexibly with minimal infrastructure and optional office solutions. SPC is especially attractive for solo consultants and boutique firms.

[Click here](#)

Trading & E-Commerce

SPC permits import, export, wholesale, retail, and online trade. Investors can use general trading or e-commerce licenses to diversify products and reach global customers. Its location supports smooth logistics and international growth.

[Click here](#)

Technology & IT

From software development to cybersecurity, SPC supports a wide range of IT businesses. Digital setup and virtual operations make it cost-efficient for startups and scalable for established firms. It is a strong base for the UAE's digital economy.

[Click here](#)

Creative & Specialist Services

SPC hosts design studios, marketing agencies, training providers, and wellness businesses.

Education, R&D, and niche creative activities are also supported. The flexibility allows entrepreneurs to innovate across multiple sectors.

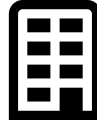
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Mainland Company Structures:



Limited Liability Company (LLC):

This is the most widely used and versatile legal structure in the UAE. It allows between 1 to 50 shareholders, with liability limited to the capital invested in the business. In most activities, 100% foreign ownership is now permitted. An LLC can operate throughout the UAE, engage in both B2C and B2B transactions, and is eligible to apply for unlimited employee visas.



Sole Establishment:

It is commonly used by individual professionals such as consultants, IT specialists, and freelancers with full control and personally liable for the company's obligations. Sole Establishments are subject to nationality restrictions – typically limited to UAE and GCC nationals, although some Free Zones allow expat ownership under certain conditions.



Civil Company:

Tailored for licensed professionals working in partnership. Civil Companies allow 100% foreign ownership in many emirates and are governed by UAE Civil Law. If the partners are foreign nationals operating on the Mainland, they may be required to appoint a UAE-based Local Service Agent (who holds no shares or managerial role).



Branch of a Foreign Company:

Allows an existing international company to expand into the UAE without incorporating a new legal entity. The branch is considered an extension of the parent company carrying out the same activities with 100% foreign ownership but requires the appointment of a UAE National Service Agent for Mainland operations.



Representative Office:

A Representative Office is a non-commercial structure used for market research, promotion, or liaison functions. It cannot conduct revenue-generating business or sign contracts in the UAE. While it offers a low-risk entry point, it is limited in scope and also requires a National Service Agent for registration.

Which Business Activities Are Permitted Under Mainland Licenses?



Commercial Activities

trading, e-commerce, retail, real estate, logistics



Professional Services

consultancy, auditing, design, legal advisory



Industrial Activities

manufacturing, processing, packaging



Sector-Specific Licenses

education, healthcare, tourism, IT, media



The Mainland Setup Process – From Initial Planning to Final License

Define Your Business Activity

All companies must align their operations with one or more official business activities listed by the DED. This choice determines your license type, visa quota, office requirements, and any special approvals needed.

Choose the Legal Structure

Select an appropriate legal form – LLC, Sole Establishment, Civil Company, Branch, or Representative Office – based on your ownership model, liability exposure, and long-term goals.

Reserve Your Trade Name

Submit 3–5 proposed business names to the DED for approval. The selected name must comply with UAE naming laws, avoid restricted terms, and reflect the licensed activity.

Obtain Initial Approval from DED

This is a no-objection clearance that permits you to proceed with document preparation and tenancy agreements. It confirms that the DED accepts your proposed structure and activity.

Draft and Notarize Legal Documents

Prepare the company's Memorandum of Association (MoA), along with any side agreements or service agent appointments. These must be notarized and signed by all shareholders.

Secure a Physical Office or Business Premises

Mainland companies require a valid lease agreement for trade license issuance. Office options include: Serviced offices, Shell & core units and Pre-fitted commercial units.

7. Final License Issuance

Once your documentation, approvals, and office lease are finalized, the DED issues your Mainland trade license.

Immigration and Visa Processing

Following license issuance, your company becomes eligible for:

Establishment card issuance

Investor and partner visas

Employee and dependent sponsorship

Open Corporate Bank Account

We build a compliant banking file with all legal, financial, and tenancy documentation.

We introduce you to aligned banking partners – local or international – and guide you through KYC, UBO, and compliance onboarding.

Tax & Compliance Registration

We register your company with:

Federal Tax Authority (Corporate Tax and VAT, as applicable)

Ministry of Economy (for ESR, UBO, and AML compliance)

What You'll Need to Legally Register a Mainland Entity

While documentation may vary by emirate and business activity, standard requirements include:

Passport copies of all shareholders and designated managers

Emirates ID and residence visa copy (if applicable)

Trade name reservation

Initial approval from the DED

Drafted and notarized Memorandum of Association (MoA)

Valid office lease or Ejari certificate

No Objection Certificate (NOC) from sponsor, if applicable

Sector-specific approvals (if required)

We Set Up Mainland Companies in Every Emirate — Here's Where and How

Dubai (DED Dubai)

Abu Dhabi (ADDED)

Sharjah

Ajman

Ras Al Khaimah

Fujairah

Umm Al Quwain

How DSA Helps

Dubai Setup Advisors (DSA) simplifies every step of your UAE business formation journey from initial planning to long-term operational support. We're not just consultants; we're your on-ground execution partners with deep expertise in UAE legal, regulatory, and commercial frameworks.

Why Choose Us?

At Dubai Setup Advisors (DSA), we go beyond basic company registration. We provide strategic guidance, legal clarity, and operational support tailored for global entrepreneurs and investors entering the UAE market. Here's why clients from over 30 countries trust us to build their presence in the Emirates.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

What is a Mainland company in the UAE?



A Mainland company is a business entity licensed by the Department of Economic Development (DED) of a specific emirate, such as Dubai, Abu Dhabi, or Sharjah. It is permitted to operate anywhere within the UAE and engage in both private and government sector work. Unlike Free Zone entities, Mainland companies are not geographically restricted and can open branches across the Emirates.

Can a foreign investor own 100% of a Mainland company?



What are the benefits of choosing a Mainland company over a Free Zone entity? +

How long does it take to establish a Mainland company in the UAE? +

What is the minimum capital required to register a Mainland company? +

What type of office is required for a Mainland company in the UAE? +

What business activities are permitted under a Mainland license? +

Can I apply for UAE residency through my Mainland company? +

What are the ongoing compliance requirements for Mainland companies? +

What are the steps involved in setting up a Mainland company? +

Can I convert my Free Zone company into a Mainland company? +

What support does DSA offer for Mainland company setup? +

Explore UAE Free Zones with DSA